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Partitions and Displacements

> ‘Two or three years after the 1947 Partition, it occurred to the governments of India and Pakistan to exchange their lunatics in the same manner as they had exchanged their criminals. The Muslim lunatics in India were to be sent over to Pakistan and the Hindu and Sikh lunatics in Pakistan asylums were to be handed over to India. It was difficult to say whether the proposal made any sense or not.’
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> —Opening lines of ‘Toba Tek Singh’, a short story by Saadat Hasan Manto (1955)

Madness. In hindsight, this word best sums up the decision to hurriedly partition the Indian subcontinent based on religious lines in 1947. Amidst horrific bloodshed, over 17 million people were pushed out, making the Partition ‘one of the largest and most rapid migrations in human history’.[1] The Partition, which led to the creation of India and Pakistan as two independent countries, was a landmark event of the 20th century but it was only one among many partitions linked with the decolonization of the British Empire after World War II. Indians were affected not only within the country but also in Burma, Sri Lanka, East Africa and the other parts of the world that they had migrated to. It was with great dismay that Indians found out that they were perceived as foreigners, just like the colonial rulers, and were not welcome to stay on after Independence.

The Partition of Pakistan in 1971 and the creation of Bangladesh were associated with another refugee crisis in eastern India, involving a